

Immigration and deprivation causing UK public to lose faith in politicians, says Rayner

Peter Walker, Senior political correspondent, *The Guardian*, Tue 22 Jul 2025

Immigration and deprivation are among the main factors causing public disenchantment with politicians and the government which has led to social unrest and rioting, Angela Rayner, the deputy prime minister, has warned.

According to an official summary of Tuesday's meeting of the cabinet, Rayner, who is leading a wider government project on improving social cohesion, also highlighted the increasing amount of time people are spending alone and online as a reason for the disturbances. Asked if Rayner saw increased migration as a particular reason for both the riots across England last summer, and recent disturbances at hotels housing asylum seekers, Downing Street said it was among "concerns that people have about whether government is acting on their behalf and acting in their interests". Ministers are concerned there could be a renewed wave of migration and race-based disturbances, as the anniversary approaches of the murder of three children at a dance class in Southport that led to riots last summer, with many encouraged by false far-right claims about the attack.

Rayner told ministerial colleagues that "economic insecurity, the rapid pace of de-industrialisation, immigration and the impacts on local communities and public services, technological change and the amount of time people were spending alone online, and declining trust in institutions was having a profound impact on society", according to a No 10 readout of the cabinet meeting on Tuesday morning.

Emphasising the role of deprivation and poverty, Rayner said 17 of the 18 places around England that had the worst trouble last summer were among the country's most deprived areas. "While Britain was a successful multi-ethnic, multi-faith country, the government had to show it had a plan to address people's concerns and provide opportunities for everyone to flourish," Rayner added.

Asked about the role of immigration, Keir Starmer's official spokesperson said "high levels of immigration over the last 10 years, including illegal immigration" was among a series of factors, including the cost of living and the pace of technological change that "have had an impact on our social fabric and social cohesion". Questioned about Rayner's comments on people spending more time online and alone, the spokesperson said adults now averaged four hours of online time a day, "and that has changed the way in which people interact with other people".

Rayner's project on social cohesion is aimed at the longer term, with no date set for it to present any conclusions. Officially known as the plan for neighbourhoods, it is intended to invest £1.5bn in 75 areas over the next decade.

However, ministers are also mindful of the more immediate worry of a repeat of last summer's disorder, after which there were more than 1,800 arrests and nearly 1,100 charges, with hundreds of people jailed.

One potential flashpoint could be an asylum hotel in Epping, Essex, which has been the target for a series of protests in recent days, and where police were attacked. The far-right agitator known as Tommy Robinson has promised on social media to bring "thousands" of people to join a mass protest at the hotel on Sunday. Similar demonstrations have taken place at a hotel in Diss, Norfolk.

There are procedures for the prime minister to be kept informed even when he is away. Starmer cancelled his summer holiday last year because of the rioting. Officials have refused to comment on any contingency plans in place this year, saying they could not "get into speculation".

There is an additional political impetus for ministers to take seriously the possibility of wider disorder given the likelihood it would be exploited by Nigel Farage, who used a speech about crime on Monday to say much of the UK was experiencing "nothing short of societal collapse". He told an event: "I don't think anybody in London can understand just how close we are to civil disobedience on a vast scale in this country."

Government officials insisted, however, that the cabinet discussion was not a response to the Reform UK leader, pointing to previous comments about the many social drivers of dissatisfaction that were made by Starmer after last year's disorder. "The broad point is that we have to invest in our social fabric," one said. "People have felt for years that governments have not delivered for them. We need to deliver change they can feel."

Among initiatives launched after the summer riots was a cross-party commission intended to examine and ease community divisions. The Independent Commission on Community and Cohesion met for the first time in June.